AMERICAN CIVIL WAR

PLUM RUN BEND



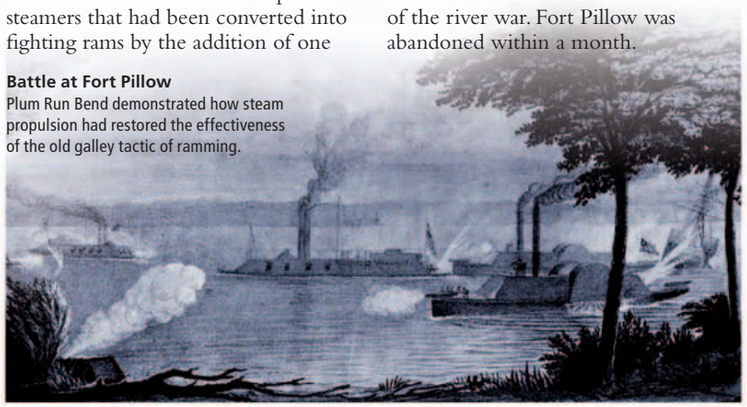
Date May 10, 1862
Forces Union: 7 ironclad gunboats, 1 wooden gunboat, 16 mortar boats; Confederacy: 8 cottonclad gunboats
Losses Union: 2 gunboats; Confederacy: none

Location Near Memphis, Tennessee

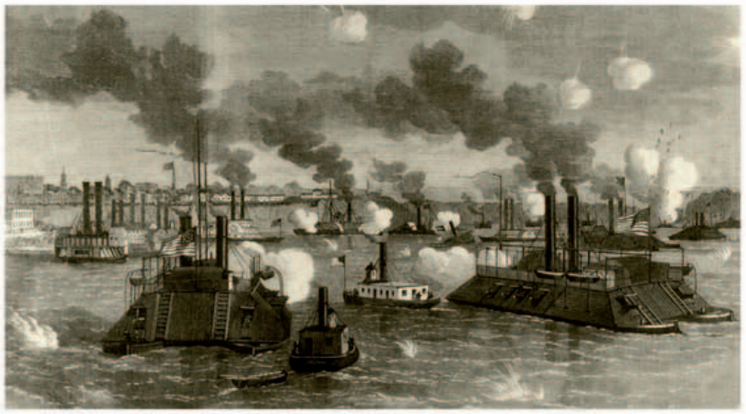
In May 1862 Union forces advancing down the Mississippi were threatening Memphis. In their path lay Fort Pillow. Union mortar boats, defended by ironclad gunboats, bombarded the fort. Captain James E. Montgomery of the Confederate River Defense Fleet commanded a small flotilla of paddle steamers that had been converted into fighting rams by the addition of one or two guns and an iron prow. They lacked iron cladding but had cotton bales functioning as light armor.

Steaming up river, Montgomery's cottonclads encountered the Union ironclad *Cincinatti*, one of the paddle-wheel gunboats known as "Pook's Turtles" after their designer Samuel Pook. Steaming through *Cincinatti*'s broadsides, three of the cottonclads rammed the gunboat, which sank in shallow water. Another ironclad, *Mound City*, was also sunk by ramming, settling half-submerged on a sandbar. As more Union gunboats rushed to the scene, the Confederates withdrew.

The skirmish at Plum Run Bend gave a welcome boost to Confederate morale but failed to affect the course of the river war. Fort Pillow was abandoned within a month.



Battle at Fort Pillow
Plum Run Bend demonstrated how steam propulsion had restored the effectiveness of the old galley tactic of ramming.



Battle of the ironclads
Union ironclad gunboats fire salvos into the Confederate fleet, bringing a swift end to the battle of Memphis.

AMERICAN CIVIL WAR

MEMPHIS



Date June 6, 1862
Forces Union: 5 ironclad gunboats, 4 rams; Confederacy: 8 cottonclads
Losses Union: none; Confederacy: 7 ships

Location Memphis, Tennessee

After their losses at Plum Run Bend in May 1862, the Union was convinced of the need for rams in river warfare. Charles Ellet, a civil engineer, had been tasked with building a ram fleet. He strengthened nine river tug boats for ramming, crewed them with riverboat men, and put them under the command of himself and his relatives. Four of Ellet's rams, together with five ironclad "Pook's Turtles," steamed down the Mississippi toward Memphis, Tennessee, on June 6. There Captain James Montgomery's cottonclads, victors of Plum Run Bend, steamed out to meet them, watched by a crowd of Memphis residents ready to cheer a Confederate triumph. But it was not to be.

Union rams, captained by Charles Ellet and his brother Alfred, collided with the van of the Confederate force at 15 knots. Two cottonclads were holed and crippled. The Union ironclad gunboats followed, firing salvoes that sank one Confederate vessel and disabled three others. After two hours' fighting, the Confederate fleet had ceased to exist, losing 180 men and only one ship escaping down river. Charles Ellet was the only casualty on the Union side. Memphis was occupied and stars and stripes raised over the Confederate city.

> "THE PASSING OF FORTS JACKSON AND ST. PHILIP WAS ONE OF THE MOST AWFUL SIGHTS I EVER SAW ..."
>
> **DAVID FARRAGUT**, UNION FLAG OFFICER, WRITING IN HIS MEMOIRS



Moonlit battle
Farragut's flagship *Hartford* runs the gauntlet of Confederate incendiaries, forcing a passage up the Mississippi.

